

Ownly in Hyderabad: Can a Bengaluru Price Playbook Travel?

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Based on our own field research in and around Gachibowli, Hyderabad: survey (58 Hyderabad and 16 Bengaluru respondents), a clickable fake-door ordering prototype (40 sessions), a three-app price audit, 6 interviews, and 524 social posts plus 37 app reviews. Company figures are media reports or company claims, not verified by us.

PART A: THE CASE

On 7 September 2026, Ownly switched on in Hyderabad. Rapido's food-delivery app arrived with a Bengaluru success story: from about 5,000 orders a day in March 2026 to a reported 50,000 by August, roughly one order in ten across the city. The obvious plan was to repeat the Bengaluru playbook. Our team spent the launch fortnight asking whether that playbook would work in Gachibowli, Hyderabad's student and IT-professional hub, and what would have to change if it didn't.

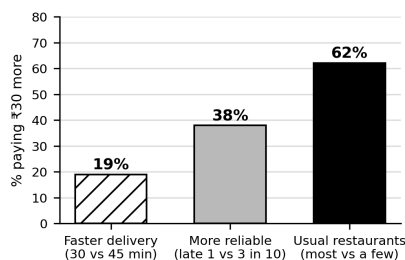


EXHIBIT 1. Share of Hyderabad respondents (n=58) paying ₹30 more for a better option. Source: team survey, Sep 2026.

HOW OWNLY WON BENGALURU

The playbook had three parts. **Customers** saw a smaller bill: no platform, packaging or surge fee. On the same four dinner orders in our audit, Ownly added ₹10 on top of the food, while Swiggy and Zomato added ₹82–84. **Restaurants** paid no commission, against a reported 16–30% on incumbents, so they could keep dine-in menu prices; Bengaluru's restaurant associations were openly threatening to boycott the incumbents. And **distribution** came free: Rapido already reached 74 million riders a month, and from July 2026 food sat inside the Rapido app.

But growth had a cost: in posts about their own orders, failed deliveries and unanswered support outnumbered saving stories almost three to one. Among the five Bengaluru respondents who had used Ownly, none would be "very disappointed" to lose it. Two used it less once offers ended, and three would otherwise have ordered the same meal on Swiggy or Zomato. **Price had won the first order, not the relationship.**

WHAT HYDERABAD CUSTOMERS TOLD US

We gave respondents the same food from the same restaurant at ₹230, or at ₹260 with one thing better. Most kept the ₹30 and accepted a slower delivery. But most *paid* the ₹30 to keep their usual restaurants (Exhibit 1). In Hyderabad, the restaurant list is the deal-breaker; speed is negotiable.

They were also already locked in: **83% hold Swiggy One or Zomato Gold.** Once membership benefits and auto-applied

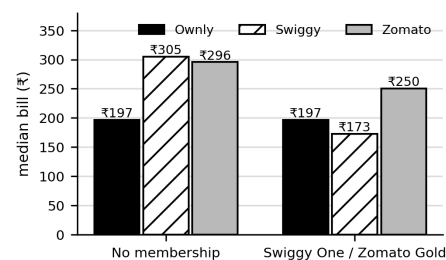


EXHIBIT 2. Median bill for the same four dinner orders. Without a membership Ownly was cheapest 4 times out of 4; against members' coupon prices, 1 time out of 4. Source: team price audit, Gachibowli.

coupons were counted, Ownly's price advantage mostly disappeared (Exhibit 2). And almost nobody trusted it to last: 84% agreed that "a new app's low prices usually go up once it becomes popular," and only 34% said they would keep using an app after a ₹100 launch offer ended.

Interest did not turn into action. 76% said they would try Ownly, but only 3 of 58 had ever ordered. The most common reason was simply "haven't got round to it"; as one interviewee said, "I have my subscription and ecosystem there." In our fake-door prototype, 3 in 10 sessions reached "Place order." A permanent food tab inside a ride app converted 4 of 7 sessions; an ad shown after a ride converted 1 of 9. When we showed two unbranded pitches, "same food, smaller bill" and "your Hyderabad regulars, dinner that turns up," respondents split almost evenly (21 vs 23). One wrote that the second "is quite similar to Swiggy already."

THE BUZZ AND THE COMPETITION

Online sentiment was turning. The negative share of posts about Ownly rose from 27% in the pilot to 51% in September 2026, driven equally by failed deliveries, support that did not respond (57% of app reviews; 43% cite slow or denied refunds) and the belief that prices would rise. And Ownly was not alone: Swiggy's budget app **Toing**, with the same no-fee promise, had reached Hyderabad six months earlier with reportedly 13 times Ownly's weekly users. Uber Eats, Foodpanda, Amazon Food and the ONDC apps had all won trial with price and lost the habit when discounts stopped or service failed.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- Which parts of the Bengaluru playbook are about the *model*, and which are about Bengaluru?
- If 83% of target customers hold a rival membership, who is Ownly's real first customer in Hyderabad?
- Stated interest was 76%; trial was 5%. What does that imply for launch spending?
- How can Ownly compete with Toing when both make the same fee promise?

PART B: OUR ANALYSIS AND RECOMMENDATION

DIAGNOSIS: WHY THE PLAYBOOK WON'T TRAVEL AS-IS

- 1. **The price edge is conditional.** It is real for people without a membership (median ₹114 cheaper) but negative against members' coupon prices (median ₹78 dearer). The typical Gachibowli respondent is a member.
- 2. **Price attracts but doesn't retain.** In both cities users came for the saving, expected it to vanish, and complained about what happened after checkout: late or missing orders and unreachable support.

3. **Hyderabad users weigh things differently.** They will wait, but they won't lose their restaurants. A generic "reliable" promise sounds like the incumbents; a "cheaper" promise sounds temporary.

Three of these results are clearly not chance. 47 of 58 accepted slower delivery for ₹30. Of the 35 people whose speed and restaurant answers differed, 30 kept their restaurants. 49 of 58 expected prices to rise. The P-vs-Q split, by contrast, is what random answers would produce.

CARRY OVER FROM BENGALURU • One honest total, with no platform or packaging fee. Fees, not food prices, made 37% of bills feel unfair. • Popular local chains as anchor supply (12 of 13 audited restaurants already listed). • Rapido as the front door, as a permanent food tab rather than after-ride ads.	DON'T COPY FROM BENGALURU • "Cheaper" as the headline. It's false for members and not believed. • Big launch discounts. Only a third would stay; Foodpanda lost 97% of orders when discounts ended. • Speed claims. Ownly quotes ~40 min vs ~21; promise an honest time instead.
IMPROVE FOR HYDERABAD • Customer service first: human chat and same-day automatic refunds for late, cold or wrong orders. • Delivery reliability: measure and publish on-time rates before spending on growth. • The restaurants people ask for, including late-night places, recruited from customer requests.	TRY NEW IN HYDERABAD • A price-lock pledge (e.g. "no platform fee until 2027") to answer the belief that cheap won't last. • Target non-members first, and first-time orderers: "no membership needed." • An on-time or money-back guarantee: something Toing's identical fee promise lacks.

THE FIRST 90 DAYS

WHEN	DO	GO ON ONLY IF
Days 0–30	Place test orders against incumbents; fix support and refunds	On-time rate is within 10 points of incumbents
Days 30–60	Onboard the restaurants customers name; launch a permanent Rapido food tab	Most named restaurants are listed
Days 60–90	Test the price-lock pledge and guarantee with non-members	Second-order rate beats a control group

LIMITS OF OUR EVIDENCE

Convenience sample of 58 Hyderabad respondents (stated choices, collected 10–14 days after launch, during a street campaign). A price audit of 4 matched orders in one dinner slot, comparing a new Ownly account with existing incumbent member accounts. Social and review data are mostly from Bengaluru, self-selected and AI-coded. Fake-door results are directional (40 sessions). Ownly's Hyderabad delivery reliability and unit economics were not measured.

The lesson: success in one city is a hypothesis for the next, not a template.

Verdict: target selectively, don't copy-paste. Ownly can survive in Hyderabad as a focused challenger. Win non-members and first-time orderers with one honest total. Build around the restaurants people won't give up. Earn the second order through service before spending on the first. Don't try to out-discount Toing or out-speed Swiggy.